ROHIT JAIN PARAS



A FRESH HAND CM Bhajan Lal Sharma with governor Kalraj Mishra and his cabinet

RAJASTHAN CABINET

SLIP-UP IN THE DESERT CHILL

By Rohit Parihar

The fledgling BJP government in Rajasthan, with a debutant chief minister, was still learning to walk when it hit the bumps. January 8 brought a particularly embarrassing setback when newly minted minister Surendarpal Singh T.T. lost in the byelection for the Karanpur assembly seat. Elections were adjourned here because of the death of the original Congress candidate. But if the BJP thought having its own regime would make the seat a cinch, it was not to be. After the 72-year-old Surendarpal lost to the new Congress candidate, 43-year-old Rupinder Singh Kooner, a visibly stunned state BJP chief C.P. Joshi was heard mumbling to reporters: "We will analyse the reasons for the defeat."

The defeat is widely seen as a sign of the people's disapproval of the way BJP has gone about government formation. It took the party a month after the results came out on December 3 to complete the process, and from the choice of the CM to ministers to bureaucrats, every move so far suggests the Centre will be lording it over the state. As expected, many local leaders and the masses have not reacted well to the new situation.

The way Union defence minister Rajnath Singh handed over a slip to ex-CM Vasundhara Raje to read out the name of Bhajan Lal Sharma as chief minister said it all. The diktat from the top was met with total silence from the newly elected MLAs. No wonder, then, that the Congress slogan, '*Parchi sarkar* (a government that runs on slips)', found much resonance during the Karanpur campaign. The saffron party's attempts to bring in a generational shift, infused with "Modi's governance style", will need some getting used to. The protagonists need some practice too. CM Bhajan Lal Sharma, a first-time MLA, is "so junior in politics" that many of his ministers have rarely or never interacted with him before. He now has 23 ministers, including two deputy CMs, to think about. Significantly, none of the ministers are staunch loyalists of ex-CM Vasundhara Raje, another sign that her era may be over. But a good number of MLAs are still from her camp and taking them along will be a challenging task for the CM who has kept the home, mines, excise and public information and relations departments for himself.

THE CM'S NAME CAME THROUGH A CHIT, ENOUGH REASON FOR THE '*PARCHI SARKAR*' IMAGE TO STICK

In the cabinet, deputy CM Diya Kumari has emerged as the most powerful entity. Given her royal background and consequent ease with a public role, she looks poised to be the actual face of the BJP government, balancing Bhajan Lal's faceless 'organisation man' image. She has also got a host of portfolios, including the all-important ones of finance and PWD. Handling the state